Poem: Ruba'iyat (Allama Muhammad Iqbal)

Stanza-by-stanza explanation — meaning, devices, theme, and likely board questions

About the Poem

Poet: Allama Muhammad Iqbal (1877–1938), philosopher-poet of Pakistan. **Form:** 3 quatrains (ruba'i form), modified AABA rhyme. **Theme:** True faith versus spiritual decline; the clash between Islamic and European civilisation; the loss of Muslim spiritual passion. Central concept: **Khudi** (selfhood).

Stanza 1

Faith is like Abraham at the stake; to be
Self-honouring and God-drunk, is faith. Hear me,
You whom this age's west captivate!
To have no faith is worse than slavery.

• **Meaning:** Faith is like Hazrat Abraham (AS) at the stake — ready to endure fire for Allah (SWT). True faith is self-honouring and God-drunk (absorbed in divine devotion). Iqbal addresses the reader directly: "Hear me, you whom this age's west captivate!" To have no faith is worse than slavery.

• **Devices:** Metaphor — faith compared to Abraham at the stake. Paradox — "God-drunk" (intoxication blended with divine ecstasy). Apostrophe — direct address to the reader ("Hear me"). Allusion — Hazrat Abraham's (AS) trial by fire (Quran 3:13).

• **Theme:** The nature of true faith. True faith is dynamic, passionate, and tested by trial — not passive or ritualistic.

• **Board angle:** "God-drunk" and "worse than slavery" are the most frequently asked phrases from this stanza.

Stanza 2

Music of strange lands with Islam's fire blends,
On which the nation's harmony depends;
Empty of concord is the soul of Europe,
Whose civilization to no Makkah bends.

• **Meaning:** The music of strange lands (Western culture) blends with Islam's fire, but the nation's harmony depends on Islam's fire, not foreign music. Europe's soul is empty of concord (harmony), and its civilisation does not bend to Makkah (does not submit to Islamic values).

• **Devices:** Juxtaposition — Europe's "empty concord" vs. Islam's "harmony." Symbolism — Makkah represents submission to Allah (SWT). Thermal imagery — "fire" (Islam's energy) vs. the coldness of Europe.

• **Theme:** The clash between civilisations. European society, despite material progress, is spiritually hollow. Islamic civilisation draws strength from divine inspiration.

• **Board angle:** The contrast between "music of strange lands" and "Islam's fire" is the key to this stanza.

Stanza 3

Love's madness has departed: in
The Muslim's veins the blood runs thin;
Ranks broken, hearts perplexed, prayers cold,
No feeling deeper than the skin.

• **Meaning:** Love's madness (religious passion) has departed from Muslims. Their blood runs thin (spiritual vitality is weak), ranks are broken (unity is lost), hearts are perplexed (confused), prayers are cold (ritual without feeling), and there is no feeling deeper than the skin (only superficiality remains).

• **Devices:** Physiological metaphor — "blood runs thin" for weakened spiritual vitality. Thermal metaphor — "prayers cold" for hollow ritual. Oxymoron — "Love's madness" reframes madness as sacred passion.

• **Theme:** The tragic decline of Muslim societies. Muslims have lost their spiritual passion and unity, reduced to superficial existence.

• **Board angle:** This is the most likely stanza for reference-to-context questions. Learn the metaphors of thin blood and cold prayers.

Overall Message

• The poem examines the nature of true faith, exemplified by Hazrat Abraham's (AS) unwavering devotion, contrasting it with the spiritual bankruptcy of the modern age.

• It reveals the fundamental clash between civilisations: European society is spiritually hollow, while Islamic civilisation draws strength from divine inspiration.

• It laments the decline of Muslim societies that have lost their spiritual passion and unity. The solution, in Iqbal's philosophy, is the revival of Khudi (selfhood).

Likely Board Questions (Reference to Context)

Q1. Explain with reference to the context: "Faith is like Abraham at the stake; to be / Self-honouring and God-drunk, is faith."

These lines from "Ruba'iyat" by Allama Muhammad Iqbal define true faith through the example of Hazrat Abraham (AS), who was prepared to endure fire for Allah (SWT). "God-drunk" describes total absorption in divine devotion — a paradox blending intoxication with ecstasy. True faith, Iqbal says, is self-honouring because it comes from the highest devotion. The lines show that faith is dynamic and passionate, not passive or ritualistic.

Q2. Explain with reference to the context: "Empty of concord is the soul of Europe, / Whose civilization to no Makkah bends."

These lines criticise European civilisation as spiritually empty. Europe's soul lacks concord — harmony and unity of hearts — despite its material progress. Its civilisation does not bend to Makkah, meaning it does not submit to or respect Islamic values. Iqbal juxtaposes Europe's spiritual hollowness with Islam's fire, which gives a nation harmony. The lines express the clash between the two civilisations.

Q3. Explain with reference to the context: "Love's madness has departed: in / The Muslim's veins the blood runs thin; / Ranks broken, hearts perplexed, prayers cold, / No feeling deeper than the skin."

These lines lament the spiritual decline of Muslims. "Love's madness" — religious passion — has departed. The metaphor of thin blood shows weakened spiritual vitality; cold prayers show hollow ritual; broken ranks show lost unity. "No feeling deeper than the skin" means Muslims now live only on the surface, without depth of feeling. The lines connect with Iqbal's concept of Khudi: without passion, selfhood dies.

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